CEM, vagueness, and uncertainty

Topics in Mind and Language: Conditionals
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1. Unfinished business: vagueness and ignorance

Consider what happens when we apply the supervaluationist approach to attitude verbs like 'know', 'be pretty certain that', etc.

Answer: typically, when 'Harry is bald' is neither supertrue nor superfalse and you know a reasonable amount about his head, 'You know that Harry is bald' and 'You know that Harry is not bald' will also be neither supertrue nor superfalse. Among the admissible interpretations are propositions you know are true, propositios you know are false, and propositions you don't know either way. Indeed, the set of propositions covers a whole spectrum of degrees of confidence.

So this view predicts that 'I don't know whether Harry is bald' is not a good thing to assert. Similarly for 'I am around X% confident that Harry is bald', and maybe also 'No-one knows who the last bald person in this Sorites sequence is'.

- Is this a good prediction? Reactions vary widely. Some opponents take it to be *obviosly* true that we don't know whether Harry is bald, and proceed from there.
- A not-so-good argument: you can't know whether Harry is bald: if you knew, why wouldn't you just answer 'Yes' or 'No' to 'Is Harry bald?'? Supervaluationist answer: both would be misleading, since they would lead people to believe/disbelieve all (or many) of the admissible interpretations, including both true and false ones.

A tempting generalisation: when you know that a sentence S is neither supertrue nor superfalse, 'You know that S' and 'You know that not-S' are neither supertrue nor superfalse.

- If this were correct, it would be problematic for the CEM defender trying to respond to the "grounding worry". The CEM defender wants to assert things like 'I don't know whether this coin would have landed Heads if tossed' (and even 'I'm about 50% sure that this coin would have landed Heads if tossed').
- However, it's not clear that the supervaluationist approach supports the idea that the tempting generalisation is true in all cases. A simple example: 'Princeton has a population of around 16,000'. (Suppose there are two admissible interpretations of 'Princeton', namely Princeton Borough and "Greater Princeton".).